

Part III — Elections

The result, and the machinery that produced it

84-355 Democracy's Data

August 2026

This is the largest part of the book, 43 chapters. It is large because “election data” is two different things that share a name.

One is the result. Who won, by how much, certified by the officials whose job is to certify it. It is the most authoritative data in this book: somebody signed their name to it.

The other is the machinery. Who was registered, who was removed from the rolls, how many ballots arrived late or were rejected, what a precinct is and where its boundary runs. Nobody signed this. It is the paperwork of running an election, published unevenly, in whatever format the office that kept it happened to use.

Both get called election data. A surprising number of published claims come from quietly swapping one for the other — using registration records to talk about who voted, or certified totals to talk about who was allowed to.

01 The result is authoritative and still not a dataset

Here is the thing that surprises people about certified returns: **there is no national file.** No federal agency collects election results and publishes them as a table. Elections are run by states, counted by counties, and certified in fifty-one different formats — a PDF here, a spreadsheet there, a web page somewhere else.

So every national number you have ever seen about an American election was assembled by somebody, privately, from those pieces. Assembly involves judgment, and judgment can be wrong. Several chapters here are about what happens at the seams.

02 The machinery is public by law and still hard to get

The second half runs into the opposite problem. The voter file is public in every state — a list of registered voters, their addresses, and whether they voted in each election. Public by law. **Downloadable in almost none of them.** You may be asked to sign something, pay something, explain yourself, or appear in person.

The chapters in this run keep hitting a version of that wall, and it is worth noticing as a pattern rather than as bad luck. *Public* and *obtainable* are different words, and the gap between them is where a lot of what we do not know about American elections actually lives.

03 The shape of this part

Every part of this book is built out of the same few moves, though no part uses all of them and the order changes when the material demands it. Here is what this one runs, and what each move is for:

Beat	Chapters	What it does
1 source	1	What this kind of data is, and what it structurally cannot say
2 instrument	1	One chapter per instrument that produces it
3 access	1	How you actually get hold of it, and what each route hands you
4 use	40	Chapters that use the data to answer a question

The rule is cumulative: **nothing in a later move is worked out from a source you have not already met.** If a chapter uses a file, the chapter that introduced that file came earlier.

Beat	Chapter	Title
1 source	returns-source	What Election Returns Can and Cannot Show
2 instrument	county-returns	Fifty-One Publishers, One Election
3 access	data-sources	County FIPS as a Join Key
4 use	levels-of-aggregation	Levels of Aggregation in Election Data
4 use	official-vs-ap	Two Publishers, One Election
4 use	electoral-map	Where Electoral Votes Are, and Where They Are Contested
4 use	mapping	Mapping Votes Against Land Area
4 use	mid-decade	The Same Votes, Redrawn
4 use	mid-decade-florida	The Same Votes, Redrawn: Florida
4 use	wind-map	Mapping Vote Swing Between Elections
4 use · companion	sparklines	A Table That Is Also Fifty-One Charts
4 use	historical-campaigns	Presidential Returns Across 150 Years
4 use	clerk-source	The Official Returns, Typeset
4 use	house-competition	Uncontested House Races, 1946-2024
4 use · companion	distributions	Distributions, and the Summaries That Hide Them
4 use	crossover	How Much of 2024 Was Already Decided in 2020
4 use	nationalization	One Election, Not Fifty
4 use	neutral-maps	Five Thousand Maps Nobody Drew
4 use	rosters-source	Who Held the Seat, and Who Won the Election
4 use	midterm-loss	The Midterm Penalty, 1858-2024
4 use	retirements	Congressional Retirements Over Two Centuries
4 use	primary-defeats	Primary Defeats of House Incumbents
4 use	primary-positions	What Candidates Would Not Say
4 use	nomination-anchors	The Dataset That Was Never Released
4 use	nomination-rules	The Rule That Picks the Nominee

Beat	Chapter	Title
4 use	careers	How Long a Congressional Career Lasts
4 use	vote-targeting	The Arithmetic of Vote Targeting
4 use	bellwether	Bellwether Counties, 1960–2024
4 use	whole-foods-cracker-barrel	Whole Foods vs. Cracker Barrel
4 use	ga-precinct-returns	Georgia Precinct Returns and the 2020 Recount
4 use	precinct-geography	Comparing Precincts Across Two Elections
4 use	cast-vote-records	Cast Vote Records and Ranked-Choice Counting
4 use	voter-files-source	What a Voter File Records, and Why
4 use	voter-file-access	Public by Law, and You Still Cannot Have It
4 use	voter-files	Reading a State Voter Registration File
4 use	false-matches	Name-and-Birthdate Matching in Voter Purges
4 use	disenfranchisement	Felony Disenfranchisement and the Voting-Eligible Population
4 use	turnout-denominator	Two Denominators for Turnout
4 use	eavs	The Election Administration and Voting Survey
4 use	residual-votes	Residual Votes and Ballot Design
4 use	seat-forecast	Forecasting the House
4 use	senate-2026	Thirty-Five Races, Rated in August
4 use	election-night	Baselines for Election-Night Forecasting

The chapter list is long. It runs the result first, all the way through, and then starts again with the machinery – which is why a second set of introductory chapters appears part-way down rather than at the top.

04 Where this part sits

Quantity	Chapters
Chapters in this part	43
Chapters elsewhere that read this part's files	7
Chapters here that read another part's files	1

7 chapters outside this part read its files, the most of any part in the book. Election returns turn out to be the thing everything else wants to be checked against: a survey's claim about turnout, a guess about who voted which way, a map's effect on an outcome. If you want to know whether a method works, you point it at a result somebody certified and see whether it gets the right answer.

05 How to read this part

The two runs can be read independently. If you want the result, start at what a return is. If you want the machinery, start at the voter file and read forward from there.

One chapter here is fixed to a date rather than a place in the sequence. Election night runs on the night of the election, with results that do not exist until then, and it grades predictions made earlier in the term against what the country actually did.

06 Sources

- The corpus itself. The chapter list, its order and each chapter's subject are read from this book's own `INDEX.md`, so this page cannot disagree with the part it opens.
- Certified returns come from the state and county officers who publish them, and from the Clerk of the U.S. House for federal races; the voter-file and administration chapters name their state sources individually. Each chapter states where its own copy came from and when it was retrieved.